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Lead Accessibility Specialist

Government Digital Service

Apply before 11:55 pm on Sunday 26th July 2026



Government
Digital Service

Reference number

470868

Salary

£69,675 - £72,975

up to £72,975 Based on capability. The base salary of this grade is £69,675 for other locations. Offers made above this will be made up with a specialist pay allowance.

A Civil Service Pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

Grade 6

Contract type

Permanent

Business area

GDS - GOV.UK

Type of role

Digital
Information Technology

Working pattern

Flexible working, Full-time, Job share, Part-time, Compressed hours

Number of jobs available

1

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Location

Bristol, Manchester

About the job

Job summary

The Government Digital Service (GDS) is the digital centre of government. We are responsible for setting, leading and delivering the vision for a modern digital government.

Our priorities are to drive a modern digital government, by:

1. joining up public sector services
2. harnessing the power of AI for the public good
3. strengthening and extending our digital and data public infrastructure
4. elevating leadership and investing in talent
5. funding for outcomes and procuring for growth and innovation
6. committing to transparency and driving accountability

We are home to the Incubator for Artificial Intelligence (I.AI), the world-leading GOV.UK and at the forefront of coordinating the UK's geospatial strategy and activity. We lead the Government Digital and Data function and champion the work of digital teams across government.

We're part of the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology (DSIT) and employ more than 1,000 people all over the UK, with hubs in Manchester, London and Bristol.

The Government Digital Service is where talent translates into impact. From your first day, you'll be working with some of the world's most highly-skilled digital professionals, all contributing their knowledge to make change on a national scale.

Join us for rewarding work that makes a difference across the UK. You'll solve some of the nation's highest-priority digital challenges, helping millions of people access services they need.

Job description

We're looking for someone who lives and breathes accessibility, inclusion and equitable design. The successful candidate will be someone who is a highly skilled expert in their field, with a passion for building public services that include everyone by design.

As an accessibility expert at GDS you'll work in [multidisciplinary teams](#), to deliver world-class, [user centred](#) public services.

You'll help identify and fix some of the toughest problems in public infrastructure and you will be focussing on design of services at scale. You'll help the government transform the way it delivers services, so that they're more efficient, simpler, faster and easier to use.

As a Lead Accessibility Specialist you'll:

- work with the Head of Design for GOV.UK to define and implement an ambitious and expansive Accessibility and Inclusion strategy, and lead on the objectives for this area

- be a subject matter expert and escalation point, leveraging your expert knowledge in accessibility and inclusion to provide practical support to teams and strategic advice to senior leaders across the programme where necessary

- support the GOV.UK programme and delivery teams to create multi-channel accessible and inclusive services that meet the WCAG standard, with effective assisted digital support models where they make sense

- champion co-design and ongoing research with disabled users and those facing barriers or broader inclusion needs, ensuring their lived experience directly shapes how GOV.UK services are designed and improved

- develop rigorous ways of tracking, measuring, assuring and documenting accessibility across the GOV.UK estate, introducing processes to ensure it

is built into all project, programme and change activity, and managing a backlog of this work across the programme

responsible for leading on how we meet our legal accessibility obligations for GOV.UK, translating requirements, standards and legislation for our project teams to understand and address issues

manage accessibility specialists and designers, developing and coaching them to pass on your skills and experience to support their learning and development goals

be an active and engaged leader in the GDS and cross government accessibility community, encouraging contribution and collaboration across organisational boundaries

Person specification

We're interested in people who:

have a track record of turning accessibility and inclusion strategy into tangible outcomes, ideally within large and complex organisations such as those in the public sector or government

are skilled at setting direction - making decisions, evaluating impact and contributing to strategic discussions at a senior level

understand and explain the ways people who are digitally excluded or have access requirements need to use services, and the things that help or hinder them

can demonstrate establishing, promoting and applying accessibility standards and other good practice guidance to products and services

have a proven track record of helping delivery teams to build services that meet the needs of users who are digitally excluded or have access needs

can apply a thorough technical knowledge of assistive hardware / software and activities related to accessibility testing

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £69,675, Government Digital Service contributes £20,184 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. [Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides \(opens in a new window\).](#)

There are many benefits of working at GDS, including:

- flexible hybrid working with flexi-time and the option to work part-time or condensed hours

- a Civil Service Pension with an average employer contribution of 28.97%

- 25 days of annual leave, increasing by a day each year up to a maximum of 30 days

- an extra day off for the King's birthday

- an in-year bonus scheme to recognise high performance

- career progression and coaching, including a training budget for personal development

- a focus on wellbeing with access to an employee assistance programme

- job satisfaction from making government services easier to use and more inclusive for people across the UK

- advances on pay, including for travel season tickets

- death in service benefits

- cycle to work scheme and facilities

- access to an employee discounts scheme

- 10 learning days per year

- volunteering opportunities (5 special leave days per year)

- access to a suite of learning activities through Civil Service learning

Any move to Government Digital Service from another employer will mean you can no longer access childcare vouchers. This includes moves between government departments. You may however be eligible for other government schemes, including Tax Free Childcare. Determine your eligibility at <https://www.childcarechoices.gov.uk>

Office attendance

The Department operates a discretionary hybrid working policy, which provides for a combination of working hours from your place of work and from your home in the UK. The current expectation for staff is to attend the office or non-home based location for 40-60% of the time over the accounting period.

DSIT does not normally offer full home working (i.e. working at home); but we do offer a variety of flexible working options (including occasionally working from home).

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our [candidate guidance \(opens in a new window\)](#) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

The standard selection process for roles at GDS consists of:

- a simple application screening process - We only ask for a CV and cover letter of up to 750 words. Important tip - please ensure that your cover letter includes how you meet the skills and experience listed in the person specification section above

- a 75 minute video interview - a short task to present back in the interview for a maximum of 15 minutes. We know life is busy for many people, so we do not expect you to spend more than 1-2 hours on this task. You will receive the task information in advance.

Depending on how many applications we get, there might also be an extra stage before the video interview, for example a phone interview or a technical exercise.

In the event we receive a high volume of applications, we will conduct the initial sift against the lead criteria which is:

- having a track record of turning accessibility and inclusion strategy into tangible outcomes, ideally within large and complex organisations such as those in the public sector or government

In the Civil Service, we use [Success Profiles](#) to evaluate your skills and ability. This gives us the best possible chance of finding the right person for the job, increases performance and improves diversity and inclusivity. We'll be assessing your technical abilities, skills, experience and behaviours that are relevant to this role.

For this role we'll be assessing you against the following [Civil Service Behaviours](#):

- working together
- changing and improving
- leadership
- developing self and others
- communicating and influencing

We'll also be assessing your experience and specialist technical skills against the following skills defined in the Government Digital and Data Capability Framework for the [Head of accessibility specialist](#) at G6 level role. However, for the Lead level, your skills will be assessed against the expectations set out below.

- Communicating information - Expert
- Governance and assurance (accessibility) - Expert
- Leadership and guidance - Practitioner
- Technical understanding (accessibility) - Practitioner
- Testing - Practitioner
- User focus - Expert

Want to know more about who Government Digital and Data are? [Click Here](#)

Recruitment Timeline

Sift completion: 31/07/2026

Panel interviews: Week commencing 10/08/2026

Candidates that do not pass the interview but have demonstrated an acceptable standard may be considered for similar roles at a lower grade.

A reserve list will be held for a period of 12 months, from which further appointments can be made.

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the [Civil Service People Plan](#) and [the Civil Service D&I Strategy](#).

Sponsorship

DSIT cannot offer Visa sponsorship to candidates through this campaign. DSIT holds a Visa sponsorship licence but this can only be used for certain roles and this campaign does not qualify.

Location:

Whilst this role's location is Bristol / Manchester, if you are a current Civil servant working in DSIT and based in London, you are also able to apply for this role. If you are successful, you will retain your London location and pay.

Security: Successful candidates must pass a disclosure and barring security check.

Please note that this role requires SC clearance, which would normally need 5 years UK residency in the past 5 years. This is not an absolute requirement, but supplementary checks may be needed where individuals have not lived in the UK for that period. This may mean your security clearance (and therefore your appointment) will take longer or, in some cases, not be possible.

For meaningful checks to be carried out, you will need to have lived in the UK for a sufficient period of time, to enable appropriate checks to be carried out and produce a result which provides the required level of assurance. Whilst a lack of UK residency in itself is not necessarily a bar to a security clearance, and expectation of UK residency may range from 3 to 5 years. Failure to meet the residency requirements needed for the role may result in the withdrawal of provisional jobs offers.

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is [security check \(opens in a new window\)](#).

[See our vetting charter \(opens in a new window\)](#).

People working with government assets must complete [baseline personnel security standard \(opens in new window\)](#) checks.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

UK nationals

nationals of the Republic of Ireland

nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK

nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status under the [European Union Settlement Scheme \(EUSS\) \(opens in a new window\)](#)

nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)

individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020

Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

[Further information on nationality requirements \(opens in a new window\)](#)

Working for the Civil Service

The [Civil Service Code \(opens in a new window\)](#) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's [recruitment principles \(opens in a new window\)](#).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

The Civil Service also offers a Redeployment Interview Scheme to civil servants who are at risk of redundancy, and who meet the minimum requirements for the advertised vacancy.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the [Civil Service People Plan \(opens in a new window\)](#) and the [Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy \(opens in a new window\)](#).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the [Great Place to Work for Veterans \(opens in a new window\)](#) initiative.

The Civil Service welcomes applications from people who have recently left prison or have an unspent conviction. [Read more about prison leaver recruitment \(opens in new window\)](#).

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Email : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Recruitment team

Email : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Further information

If you feel your application has not been treated in accordance with the Recruitment Principles and you wish to make a complaint, you should contact gds-complaints@dsit.gov.uk in the first instance.

If you are not satisfied with the response you receive you can contact the Civil Service Commission by email: info@csc.gov.uk Or in writing: Civil Service Commission, Room G/8 1 Horse Guards Road, London, SW1A 2HQ.

